

Hard Reset: Dancing Through The Noise

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Abstract — In a time when algorithmic curation has overtaken collective meaning-making, *Hard Reset: Dancing Through the Noise* explores glitch as both a material and metaphorical strategy for resisting digital determinism and cultivating new forms of public assembly. This paper situates glitch aesthetics within a broader lineage of technological resistance - from analog media disruptions to the commercialization of visual error - framing glitch not as malfunction but as an actant that invites reflection, play, and reorientation. Drawing from the work of Hannah Arendt, Adrienne Maree Brown, Rosa Menkman, the project investigates how technological failure and sensory distortion can generate joy, connection, and radical presence.

The installation, staged as a one-night party, used a suite of real-time audiovisual glitches - databending, pixelation, pixel sorting, data moshing, and generative AI image transitions - each responsive to crowd movement and musical rhythm. CRT televisions and projectors displayed feedback loops and shifting visual disruptions that were only activated through dancing, reinforcing the idea that togetherness fuels visibility. The event's unexpected twists - including a last-minute venue change and a surprise line dancing segment - ultimately enhanced its conceptual grounding, highlighting the creative and communal potential of glitch.

Hard Reset reframes pleasure not as escape but as resistance—an embodied, collaborative defiance of digital fragmentation. In the face of siloed realities, curated feeds, and algorithmic echo chambers, this project asks: what becomes possible when we dance through the noise?

Theoretical Framework

Assembly occurs when disparate entities, both human and non-human, come together to form a collective. In this convergence lies an amplification of potential, a magnification of ability that exceeds the sum of its parts. To assemble is not only to be together, but to become something more through togetherness. Assembly also generates a public: a space where people can see and be seen, allowing them to verify each other's realities. As Hannah Arendt states in her book, *The Human Condition*, "The presence of others who see what we see and hear what we hear assures us of the reality of the world and ourselves, and while the intimacy of a fully developed private life ... will always greatly intensify and enrich the whole scale of subjective emotions and private feelings, this intensification will always come to pass at the expense of the assurance of the reality of the world and men."¹

While such assemblies and publics once required a physical presence, new technologies have resulted in a shift in these public spheres from in-person gatherings to online platforms. In a world where the phone is nearly an extension of the human body and digital platforms are the

¹ Hannah Arendt and Margaret Canovan, *The Human Condition: Second Edition* (University of Chicago Press, 1998).

new commons, a new paradox has been produced: everything is now public, and nothing is public. On the one hand, people are never truly alone. Constantly plugged in, individuals are endlessly interacting with and influencing each other online. On the other, our realities are algorithmically filtered, personalized, and splintered. What appears as a shared digital space is in fact a series of curated solitudes.

This contradiction is mirrored within technology today. Social media platforms thrive on confirmation bias, reinforcing pre-existing beliefs and pulling individuals further apart into their own individual realities. Everything is polarized. At the same time, generative AI and the way it is trained on large datasets is leading to the convergence of “average” opinions, aesthetics, and language. Everything is averaged.

everything is public	nothing is public
everything is averaged	everything is polarized

Figure 1 — Major contradictions existing in publics and technology today.

In this world of contradictions, it becomes impossible to focus, to remain oriented and sure of the worlds we have constructed in our minds. Clarity feels unattainable, and in this complexity and chaos, it becomes difficult to find meaning.

One framework that begins to address existing in such confusion is Adrienne Maree Brown’s (AMB) concept of pleasure activism. AMB describes this concept best by breaking down its components in her book, *Pleasure Activism, The Politics of Feeling Good*.

“Pleasure is a feeling of happy satisfaction and enjoyment. Activism consists of efforts to promote, impede, or direct social, political, economic, or environmental reform of stasis with the desire to make improvements in society. Pleasure activism is the work we do to reclaim our whole, happy, and satisfiable selves from the impacts, delusions, and limitations of oppression and/or supremacy.”²

AMB expresses through her writing that political resistance doesn’t just have to come in traditional forms such as protesting or lobbying. In fact, in her essay “Love As Political Resistance,” AMB goes so far as to propose love as a form of political resistance, urging readers to stop loving as we have been just because it is how we always have been. She discusses a departure from traditional love marred by obligation, transactional in nature, and valued only if romantic. She counters with the notion of a love that involves radical honesty,

² “Pleasure Activism: The Politics of Feeling Good – Highlander Research and Education Center,” accessed March 11, 2025, <https://highlandercenter.org/product/pleasure-activism/>.

healing, and change. AMB argues for creating spaces and experiences of pleasure as a way to combat one of the biggest challenges facing society today: complacency.

Glitch

Love resists complacency by deepening how we care for one another. Similarly, glitch resists complacency in how we engage with and interpret technology. Throughout history, there have been artistic responses to the realism that emerges from new technologies. For example, abstraction came about as a response to renaissance-based visual representation. More recently, glitch aesthetics became a response to photography.

Before glitch was an aesthetic, it was an error. Coined by astronaut John Glenn, the word “glitch” was originally used to describe changes in voltage in an electrical current that could not be explained.³ It was a malfunction with no aesthetic value. However, as photography created a whole new quality of realness to visual representation, glitch began to be used as a mode of creating art. This can be seen through the light leaks in Andy Warhol’s films, Nam June Paik’s distortion of CRT television signals, and net art such as that by Ant Scott or the art duo called Jodi.⁴⁵

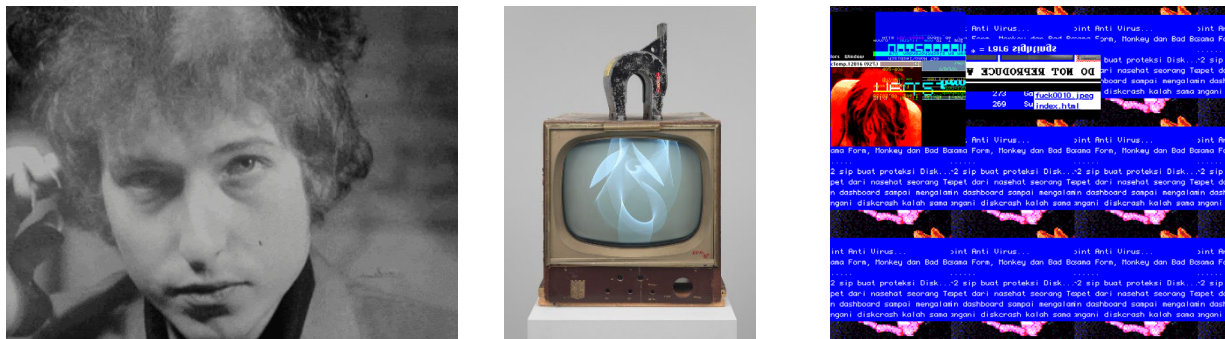


Figure 2 (left) — Warhol film of Bob Dylan showing hints of light leaks; **Figure 3 (center)** — Nam June Paik’s CRT tv using a magnet to distort the signal; **Figure 4 (right)** — A screen capture from one of Jodi’s websites exhibiting net glitch.⁶

Another defining moment for the glitch aesthetic movement came in 2009 when Kanye West disrupted the glitch art scene by coming out with his “Welcome to Heartbreak” music video, which used traditional glitch techniques. This represented the commercialization of glitch art, serving as a polarizing moment for glitch artists. While some artists, such as Paul B. Davis, were concerned for what this commercialization meant for the ability of glitch to critique society,

³ “The Glitch Moment(Um),” *Furtherfield* (blog), April 12, 2012, <https://www.furtherfield.org/the-glitch-momentum/>.

⁴ Carolyn L. Kane, “Compression Aesthetics: Glitch From the Avant-Garde to Kanye West,” *InVisible Culture*, no. 21 (September 1, 2014), <https://doi.org/10.47761/494a02f6.8aebfcc0>.

⁵ “The Glitch Moment(Um).”

⁶ “%Transfer | HQX,” accessed April 15, 2025, <https://www.wwwwwwwww.jodi.org/100cc/hqx/i906.html>.

others were more accepting of the newfound mainstream nature of the glitch aesthetic.⁷ In her piece, *The Glitch Moment(um)*, glitch artist Rosa Menkman states, “An intended or designed error can still rightfully be called glitch art; and glitch art is not always just a personal experience of shock, but can be a metaphorical expression, dependent upon multiple agents for interpretation.”⁸ Through her writings, Menkman has served as a champion of the glitch movement, expressing that, “Like the best ideas, glitch practices are dangerous because they generate awareness.”⁹ She, like many other artists, uses glitch as a form of resistance.

Hard Reset: The Plan

This project proposes glitch as both a material and metaphorical strategy for disrupting the algorithmic systems that increasingly shape our realities – offering a space where technological failure becomes a site of resistance and collective embodiment. The project will focus on achieving the following goals:

To resist complacency in the face of algorithmic determinism

To foster joy through embodied disruption

To create a public assembly of people with glitch as the nonhuman actor

To celebrate the new discoveries made through the chaos and glitch of togetherness

The mode for this project will be a glitch-themed party. As participants dance, designed glitches will change and intensify. The glitches will be in the form of audio, visual, and lighting, each responding to a combination of the music being played by a DJ and the movement of a crowd.

Hard Reset: The Execution

The night consisted of several different types of glitches: databending, pixelation, double exposure, and data moshing. For all of these glitch audiovisuals, motion of the crowd was detected using a cache-to-live comparison. The higher the levels of motion detected, the more sensitive the audiovisuals became to the kick and snare of the music being played by the DJ, resulting in more significant glitches as the crowd moved more. If no crowd movement was detected, only static played.

⁷ Kane, “Compression Aesthetics.”

⁸ “The Glitch Moment(Um).”

⁹ “The Glitch Moment(Um).”

In addition to the glitch audiovisuals, a generative AI audiovisual was also developed. This tool used a stable diffusion API to produce ever-evolving images that moved with the music and represented an additional level of unpredictability and new discoveries.



databending

The manipulation of data inside of a file, producing a glitch.¹⁰

One week and two days left. I seek final approval of the Queens Head Pub venue from the MDes administration. Denied. A shift in the backend. A new venue, a new time, a new date. Beer N Dogs. In two days.



pixelation

A loss of resolution resulting in fewer, larger pixels.

Two days left. Not everything will get done. Time to choose. A loss of lighting and audio glitch effects. Focus on audiovisuals. Goal is to maintain visibility of concept despite loss of resolution.



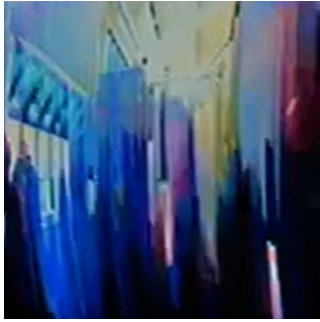
double exposure

The superimposition of two different images to create one image.¹¹

Not originally my event. Beer N Dogs team wanted a line dancing event. Had to accommodate. Techno and line dancing mashed into one night. Digital glitch and western dance. Independent but with the same goal: moving the crowd.

¹⁰ Nadiia Chervinska, "Glitch Art: Exploring the Aesthetics of Digital Error and Distortion," *Depositphotos Blog* (blog), July 9, 2023, <https://blog.depositphotos.com/glitch-art.html>.

¹¹ Chervinska.



pixel sorting

The algorithmic sorting the pixels of an image, commonly by color.¹²

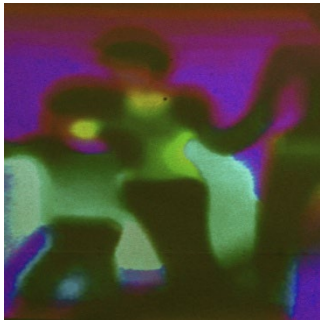
People sorted themselves into spectators, dancers, leaders. Some watched themselves in the CRT televisions. Others danced in the middle of a circle of observers. Some joined in for the line dancing, reveling in the energy.



data moshing

The bleeding of information from one frame to the next.¹³

Songs changed. Visuals shifted as people passed in front of the camera. The theme moved from glitch to western and back to glitch. Yet from frame to frame, there was dancing, there was community, and there was joy.



generative ai

A text-to-image model and random seeds produced changing images.

From the urgency and error came new discoveries. Line dancing was a happy accident, bringing people in. The tech led to questions from the crowd and new relationships. The glitches led to shared conversations and intrigue.

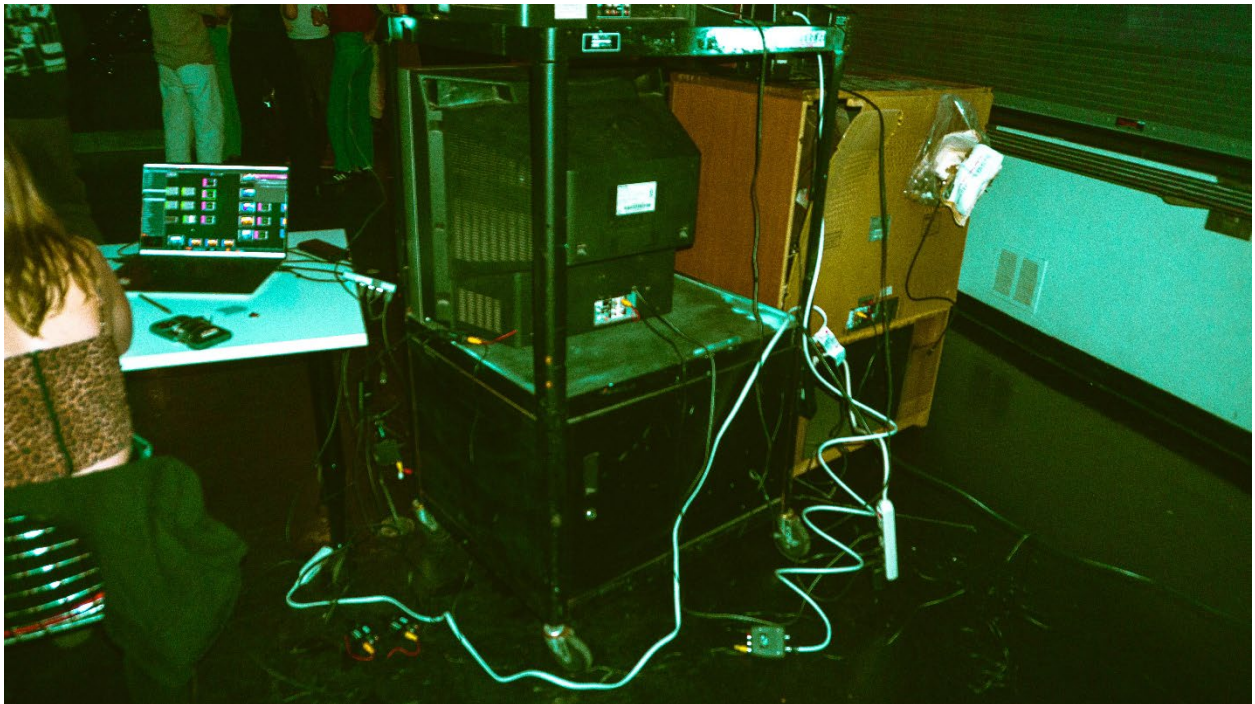
¹² Chervinska.

¹³ Chervinska.

Hard Reset: A Photo Journal



No crowd = no visuals. Static on the CRT televisions.



Wired in. The television and projector setup took two laptops and over 10 computer ports.



The CRT televisions added a retro flare.



A lone king kicks off the dancing in a dance circle.



People watch themselves in the CRT televisions.



People are shown being glitched and distorted in the CRT televisions.



A dancer sneaks “backstage.”



A crowd begins to assemble.



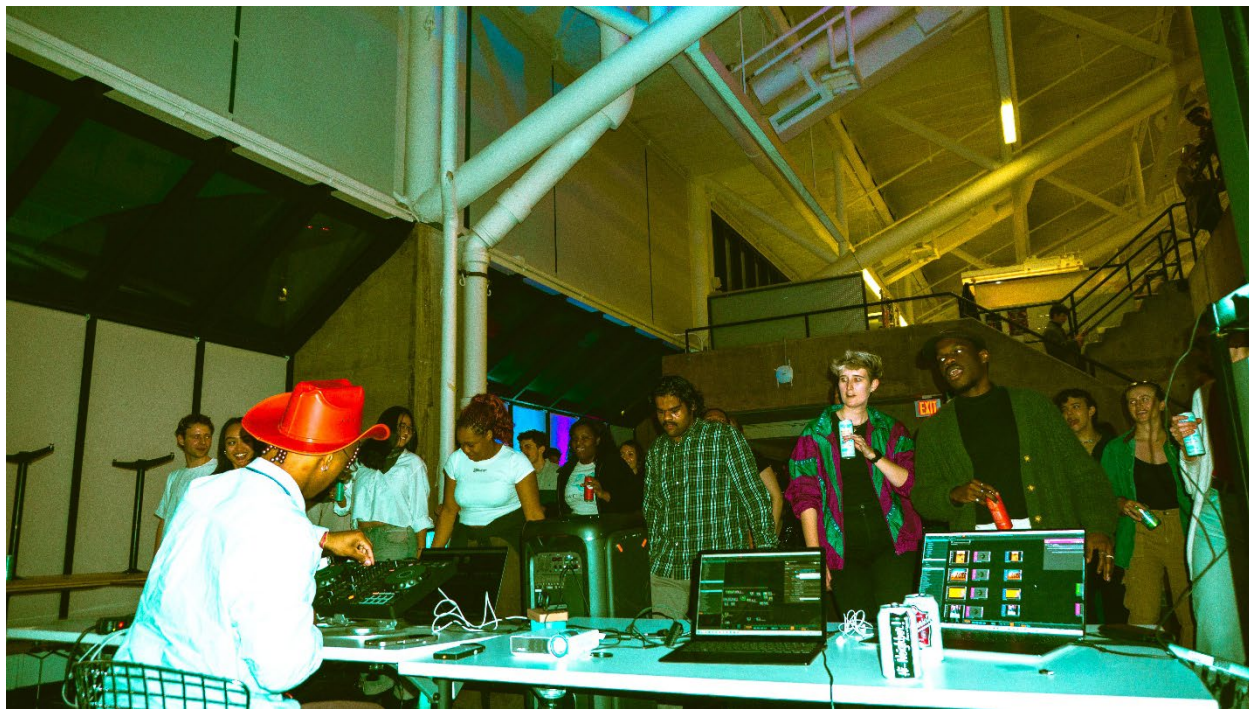
Double exposed. The DJ switches into a cowboy hat for the line dancing switch-up.



People line up for the line dancing.



Line dancing introduces a new form of togetherness and enthusiasm to the crowd.



Behind the scenes. The DJ adjusting his set. The laptops running the visuals.



More than meets the eye. The live audiovisuals are run by a web of code and components.



The calm before the storm. Enjoying the moments between setup and people arriving.